Ratan was also keen to avoid any unnecessary embarrassment to Mistry. He wanted to extend a face-saving formula by giving him an option to resign. Ratan proposed to meet Mistry on the day of the board meeting minutes before it began, and give him the option. To make things simple, he thought it expedient to draft and take the resignation letter that the chairman could sign when they met.

If Mistry agreed, he could sign the resignation letter at the meeting itself. Achieving secrecy would serve both well—Mistry could escape the ignominy of becoming the first chairman of Tata Sons to be replaced, and the board the embarrassment of being the first to ever force the removal of one. His resignation would also avoid unnecessary division in the conglomerate as he was the chairman of some of the well-known group companies.

The Denouement

On Tuesday, 24 October 2016, the Tata Sons board was scheduled to meet at 3 p.m. Ratan spent the first half of the morning at his home, Halekai. He had woken up an hour or so before he normally did. He went through his papers and spent nearly thirty minutes playing with his German Shepherds, Tito and Tango. As usual, it was a time he devoted entirely to them, and it transported him away from all his mundane thoughts. In difficult times, his dogs are his favourite companions.

Breakfast consisted of only a cup of tea. He did not wear a suit that day. He used to do that only when he was chairman, Tata Sons, and would attend its board meetings. He wore a full shirt without a jacket and tie as he did on usual days. As always, he chose the shirt himself.

At about 11.30 a.m., he reached the twenty-sixth floor of the World Trade Centre, the office of the Tata Trusts, for the special meeting of the trustees that he had called. The office is spartan and minimalistic, and could be mistaken as one belonging to a struggling start-up. But it reflects Ratan’s style. The boardroom too is very ordinarily appointed with a table and chairs to accommodate a dozen people. It doubles as a makeshift dining table for Ratan when he invites his friends over for lunch, to eat out of plastic disposable lunch boxes that are ordered from a nearby caterer.

The trustees were already seated. They did not know what they were to discuss that day. No specific agenda had been circulated for the meeting.